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The Book of Chronicles

An exploration of the book of ‘things omitted’

Biblical excerpts taken from the NRSV

Abstract

The Bible is a subversive and counter-cultural book that invites us to participate in a story that expands beyond itself.

- The following will explore the books of first and second Chronicles.
- The goal is to analyze the Chronicler’s unique historical perspective to gain an enriched understanding of his theology.
- **This outline is NOT about inerrancy** (the idea that the Bible is without error).
- Traditional views maintain that the Bible is univocal (it speaks with one voice) and inerrant (it contains no errors). While not the stated goal, this outline will likely evoke questions concerning these two doctrines.
- Ehrman, Bart. *Jesus Interrupted*

> A Christianity dependent on the inerrancy of the Bible probably cannot survive the reality of the discrepancies. *But there are lots of other forms of the Christian faith, many of them unscathed by the fact that the Bible is not a completely perfect book* (59 emphasis added).

- Inerrantists and apologists have dealt with the topics contained in this outline. Readers can find their explanations. These explanations will not be dealt with here.
- Readers are encouraged, for the remainder of this outline, to let go of the need to defend the Bible. Good faith questions are encouraged, but discussions of inerrancy are better suited for a separate study.
- **This outline will proceed under the assumption that the books of Samuel, Kings, and Chronicles were written at different times, by different people for different audiences.** As such, they may say different things.
  - This does not insinuate that the books are any less ‘inspired’ by God.

    - In other words, the *authority* of scripture is not in question by this outline.
- Since these books are in our Bible for a reason, let's take a look Chronicles.
- Approach this subject with an open mind.

In The Beginning

You Are Here

- Chronicles is a retelling of the stories found in Samuel/Kings.
- In the Hebrew Bible, this book is placed at the *end.* Its current place in our Bible is a result of the Greek Translation (Enns TEOA 52).
- The Hebrew Bible Introduction to 2 Chronicles provided by Diane V.

> Originally one book called *Divre-HaYamin* or "The Words of the Days," Chronicles was divided in the Greek Septuagint and titled "Of Things Omitted" (events not included in 1 and 2 Samuel and 1 and 2 Kings). The name "Chronicles" comes from the Latin Vulgate, which called the book "The Chronicles of the Whole of Sacred History."

- Enns, Peter. *The Evolution of Adam*

> *Chronicles is a retelling of Israel's story in light of the return from exile.* It is Israel's declaration that, despite the exile, the same God back then is still with God's people today. Whatever else may have changed, Yahweh is still their God (52).

- Enns, Peter. *The Bible Tells Me So*

> Samuel/Kings was written while the Israelites were in exile in Babylon (sixth century BCE) and probably edited and updated sometime after they came back to the land (late sixth to fifth century BCE). The pressing question for the writer was, "How did we end up in Babylon, in exile from our homeland, when we thought God would stick with us no matter what? What did we do to deserve it?" They were trying to wrap their heads around what happened.
>
> Chronicles was written much later, two hundred years or so, probably sometime in the fourth century BCE at least, after the Israelites had been back in the land for generations. This writer's question wasn't "What did we do to deserve this?" but "After all this time, are we still the people of God? Is God ever going to show up and fix this mess? What is our future? Do we *have* a future?"
>
> These two agendas are galaxies apart, and they yielded two *profoundly* different stories of Israel's monarchy (91 - 92).

- The Chronicler begins his story with nine chapters of genealogies.
- Genealogies are typically not the most thrilling reading, so this outline will only focus on the first name: Adam.
- The Chronicler ties Israels history all the way back to Adam. Whether or not you believe there was a historical man called Adam is irrelevant: The Chronicler is connecting Israel to God through creation itself (Japhet 92, see below).

- Enns, Peter. *The Evolution of Adam*

> Connecting postexilic Israel to its preexilic glory days is why 1 Chronicles begins with nine chapters of names. Most readers today gladly skip over them, but for postexilic Israelites, the genealogy made a vital point: it traced Israel's history from the postexilic period all the way back to Adam. (1 Chron. 1:1 is the only explicit reference to Adam in the Old Testament after Gen. 5)
>
> Thus, Chronicles is a postexilic rewriting of Israel's entire history to remind the Israelites that they are still the people of God — regardless of all that has happened and regardless of how much they have deserved every bit of misery they have received. They remain God's people, and their lineage extends to the very beginning, to Adam (54).

- **Why is it important to remember where we come from? Who we are? *Whose* we are?**

The Meat

What are we about to get into?

- Chronicles is different from Samuel/Kings.
- Japhet, Sara*. The Ideology of the Book of Chronicles*

> (2) The material found in Chronicles is primarily of two kinds: material taken from various sources and transposed, at times verbatim, at times with drastic changes, and material written by the book's author. Certain important conclusions may be deduced from this point:
>
> a) The Chronicler's principal sources were the biblical books that preceded him, notably Samuel-Kings. When we compare Chronicles to its source texts, we discover changes — changes of language, style, content, and ideology. It may be that a few of these differences already appeared in the Chronicler's Vorlage, but most of them were his own work, and they give us a clear picture of his world-view (6).

- What can we say about these differences? *Why* are there differences?
- Japhet, Sara. *The Ideology of the Book of Chronicles*

> An examination of Chronicles' reworking of historical events shows that:
>
> 1. in the case of any transgression (described as such in Samuel-Kings or conceived as such by the Chronicler), an appropriate punishment is added by the Chronicler;

2. Whenever righteousness or piety is displayed with no mention of recompense, the Chronicler adds a fitting reward;
3. every difficulty, affliction, and defeat is automatically perceived as retribution. For this reason, when an incident which might be a punishment remains unexplained, the Chronicler adds a suitable sin;
4. every success, whether personal or public, is considered a reward. Whenever a possible reward is mentioned without the appropriate causes for it, the Chronicler provides the source of merit;
5. if two occurrences, one a possible sin, the other an apparent punishment, are described independently, the Chronicler makes a causal connection between the two (130 - 131).

- Keep these points in mind as we continue to read excerpts from Chronicles.
- **Reflect on the above points. Why might the Chronicler want to alter history in this way?**

David

- David is portrayed differently in Chronicles than he is in Samuel/Kings.
- Stories that draw attention to David's actual or perceived failings are systematically omitted from Chronicles (Japhet 365):
    a. The story of Bathsheba (2 Samuel 11)
    b. The story of Uriah (2 Samuel 11)
    c. The rape of Tamar (2 Samuel 13)
    d. Absalom's rebellion (2 Samuel 15 - 18)
    e. Sheba's uprising (2 Samuel 20)
    f. David's appointment of Solomon (compare 1 Kings 2 to 1 Chronicles 29)
- There are different views on *why* David is portrayed differently
    a. To magnify David as the ideal king; minimizing any moral inadequacies (Japhet citing Gerhard von Rad 80, Enns TEOA 54). This is the majority view.
    b. To magnify God (Japhet 364 - 372). Japhet argues:

> Thus, although it is true that many sources to David's discredit have been omitted and elements enhancing his reputation have been

added, the book of Chronicles does not present David as an idealized, perfect figure.

- By changing aspects of David's story, the Chronicler projects sin onto David by which to justify God's actions.

- Nathan's prophecy to David:

2 Samuel 7: 12-17	1 Chronicles 17: 11-15
When your days are fulfilled and you lie down with your ancestors, I will raise up your offspring after you, **who shall come forth from your body**, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for **my name**, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. I will be a father to him, and he shall be a son to me. **When he commits iniquity, I will punish him with a rod such as mortals use, with blows inflicted by human beings.** But I will not take my steadfast love from him, as I took it from **Saul**, whom I put away from before you. **Your** house and **your** kingdom shall be made sure forever before me; **your** throne shall be established forever. In accordance with all these words and with all this vision, Nathan spoke to David.	When your days are fulfilled to go to be with your ancestors, I will raise up your offspring after you, **one of your own sons**, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for **me**, and I will establish his throne forever. I will be a father to him, and he shall be a son to me. I will not take my steadfast love from him, as I took it from **him who was before you**, but I will confirm him in **my** house and in **my** kingdom forever, and **his** throne shall be established forever. In accordance with all these words and all this vision, Nathan spoke to David.

- Chronicles emphasizes that it is not David's house and kingdom but rather *God's* house and *God's* kingdom that will be established.

- On retribution theology: Higashi, Aaron. *1 & 2 Samuel For Normal People*

> This is a big part of the theology that Israel used after the Babylonian exile in the 6th century BCE to make sense of why they were so thoroughly defeated. Generally, if a nation was defeated in the ancient world, it was believed that the nation's god had been defeated by another god. But the biblical authors couldn't tolerate this conventional explanation, so they came up with this idea that God had agreed to support the monarchy only if the king obeyed. If the king didn't, though, God would destroy the people of Israel. This allowed later Israelite authors to say their

> defeat by Babylon wasn't a defeat of Yahweh at all; rather, it was Yahweh's will (41).

- The Census

2 Samuel 24:1	1 Chronicles 21:1
Again **the anger of the Lord was kindled against Israel, and he incited David** against them saying, "Go, count the people of Israel and Judah."	**Satan stood up against Israel, and incited David** to count the people of Israel.

- The Chronicler changes the instigator of the census from "the Lord" to "Satan."
  - "Satan" should probably be understood as an "adversary" as in the book of Job (Japhet 114 - 115, Job 1: 6-12).
- **Put yourself in the Chronicler's shoes. What would it mean for *the Lord* to incite David to take the census? How would you handle this passage absent the Chronicler's perspective?**
- Japhet, Sara. *The Ideology of the Book of Chronicles*

> According to 2 Sam 24:1, it was God in His wrath who wished to harm Israel. We are not informed of the reasons for YHWH's anger — perhaps it was aroused by some sort of sin. In any case, it is clear that David is merely God's instrument to carry out His will. We therefore understand why David disregards Joab's attempts to dissuade him from taking the census (2 Sam 24:3).
>
> In 1 Chr 21:1, God does not initiate the course of events, and there is no suggestion of any divine wrath. The possibility that the people might have sinned is not even mentioned. Only one thing happens: David succumbs to his adversary's incitement. Joab's words now represent the will of God, and David ignores them (1 Chr 21:3, 6).
>
> The change to the beginning of the story may be explained by the Chronicler's inability to accept the image of God expressed in 2 Samuel 24. Because of his desire to alter this image, the Chronicler depicts David as acting independently and, as a consequence, also magnifies his sin. David is no longer God's instrument; he himself brings disaster upon Israel through his own actions (369).

- Or, more concisely: Higashi, Aaron. *1 & Second Samuel For Normal People*

> Since this is theologically problematic and contradicts the kind of fatherly relationship God committed to in 2 Samuel 7, 1

> Chronicles 21:1 changes the story so that Satan incites David to take the census instead (106).

The Middle

Putting the Kings in Kings

- The Chronicler had many goals when rewriting the stories found in Samuel/Kings.
- These goals can be discovered by evaluating the Chronicler's consistent and systematic process of addition, deletion, and alteration of his source texts.
- There are too many changes of this sort to enumerate in this outline. Readers are encouraged to read Samuel/Kings and Chronicles in parallel to view these differences.
- How could two histories be different? Why would the Chronicler do this?
- Smith, Mark S. *The Early History of God*

> For the biblical record, the order of history is not theologically tantamount to the order of reality. Hence, understanding Yahweh involves a theological interpretation of history that, according to the biblical perspectives, permits the nature of Yahweh to be disclosed more fully. While drawing on older tradition and claiming basis in Israel's earliest history, later prophetic and legal materials reflect a sustained reflection concerning Yahweh, supplementing and correcting older incomplete renderings of the divine (202).

- The Biblical authors did not see a problem with rewriting history to explain their reality.
- While not exhaustive, below are a few examples of changes the Chronicler has made to his sources:

1 Kings 10:9	**2 Chronicles 9:8**
Blessed be the Lord your God, who has delighted in you and set you on **the throne of Israel!** Because the Lord loved Israel forever, he has made you king to execute justice and righteousness.	Blessed be the Lord your God, who has delighted in you and set you on **his** throne as king for the Lord your God. Because your God loved Israel and **would establish them** forever, he has made you king over them, that you may execute justice and righteousness.

1 Kings 14:25	2 Chronicles 12: 5-6
In the fifth year of King Rehoboam, King Shishak of Egypt came up against Jerusalem;	Then the prophet Shemaiah came to Rehoboam and to the officers of Judah, who had gathered at Jerusalem because of Shishak, and said to them, "**Thus says the Lord: You abandoned me, so I have abandoned you to the hand of Shishak.**" Then the officers of Israel and the king humbled themselves and said, "**The Lord is in the right.**"

1 Kings 15:16	2 Chronicles 16: 7 - 9 (abridged)
There was war between Asa and King Baasha of Israel all their days.	7. At that time the seer Hanani came to King Asa of Judah, and said to him, "Because you relied on the king of Aram, and did not rely on the Lord your God, the army of the king of Aram has escaped you. 9. … You have done foolishly in this; for from now on you will have wars.

1 Kings 22:32	2 Chronicles 18:31
When the captains of the chariots saw Jehoshaphat, they said, "It is surely the king of Israel." So they turned to fight against him; and Jehoshaphat cried out.	When the captains of the chariots saw Jehoshaphat, they said, "It is the king of Israel." So they turned to fight against him; and Jehoshaphat cried out, **and the Lord helped him. God drew them away from him,**

2 Kings 8:22	2 Chronicles 21:10
So Edom has been in revolt against the rule of Judah to this day. Libnah also revolted at the same time.	So Edom has ben in revolt against the rule of Judah to this day. At that time Libnah also revolted **against his** [Jehoram's] **rule, because he had forsaken the Lord, the God of his ancestors.**

2 Kings 14:11	2 Chronicles 25: 20-21
But Amaziah would not listen. So King Jehoash of Israel went up; he and King Amaziah of Judah faced one another in battle at Beth-shemesh, which belongs to Judah.	But Amaziah would not listen **— it was God's doing, in order to hand them over, because they had sought the gods of Edom.** So King Joash of Israel went up; he and King Amaziah of Judah faced one another in battle at Beth-Shemesh, which belongs to Judah.

2 Kings 23:29	2 Chronicles 35: 20 - 21
In his days Pharoh Neco king of Egypt went up to the king of Assyria to the river Euphrates. King Josiah went **to meet him;** **but when Pharoh Neco met him at Megiddo, he killed him.**	After all this, when Josiah had set the temple in order, King Neco of Egypt went up to fight at Carchemish on the Euphrates, and Josiah went **out against him.** **But Neco sent envoys to him, saying "What have I to do with you, king of Judah? I am not coming against you today, but against the house with which I am at war; and God has commanded me to hurry. Cease opposing God, who is with me, so that he will not destroy you."**

- The following are stories with no parallel in Kings.
- 2 Chronicles 13: 15-18

> Then the people of Judah raised the battle shout. And when the people of Judah shouted, **God defeated** Jeroboam and all Israel before Abidjan and Judah. The Israelites fled before Judah, and **God gave them into their hands.** Abidjan and his army defeated them with great slaughter; five hundred thousand picked men of Israel fell slain. Thus the Israelites were subdued at that time, and the people of Judah prevailed, **because they relied on the Lord, the God of their ancestors.**

- 2 Chronicles 14: 11-14

> Asa cried to the Lord his God, "O Lord, there is no difference for you between helping the mighty and the weak. Help us, O Lord our God, for we rely on you, and in your name we have come against the multitude. O Lord, you are our God; let no mortal prevail against you." **So the Lord defeated the Ethiopians** before Asa and before Judah, and the Ethiopians fled. Asa and the army with him pursued them as far as Gerar, and the Ethiopians fell until no one remained alive; **for they were broken before the Lord and his army**. The people of Judah carried away a great quantity of booty. They defeated all the cities around Gerar, **for the fear of the Lord was on them.** They plundered all the cities; for there was much plunder in them.

- Smith, Mark S. *The Early History of God*

> Judah's reduced status on the world scene also required new thinking about divinity. Like Marduk, Yahweh became an "empire-god," the god of all the nations but in a way that no longer closely tied the political fortunes of Judah to the status of this god. With the old order of divine king and his human, royal representation on earth reversed, Yahweh stands alone in the divine realm, with all the other gods as nothing. In short, the old head-god of monarchic Israel became the Godhead of the universe (194).

- The exile forced Judah to change their perception of God. They could have given up; thrown in the towel.

- The exile could have been seen as proof that Yahweh was *not* their God. That Yahweh was *not* in control. **Yet**, here the Chronicler is making deliberate changes and placing strong emphasis on Yahweh as the God of Israel; The one true God who is still in charge.
- In the examples above, God is sovereign over events. **In times of crisis, why is it important to remember that God is sovereign and active in the world?**

- Below is a verse regarding the Lord's covenant:

1 Kings 8:21	2 Chronicles 6:11
There I have provided a place fo ark, in which is the covenant of the that he made **with our ancestors** **when he brought them out of the** **of Egypt.**	There I have set the ark, in which is the covenant of the that he made **with the people of** **Israel.**

- Japhet, Sara. *The Ideology of the Book of Chronicles*

> By leaving "our fathers" out of the picture, the Chronicler frees the covenant from any particular time frame. Now it is with "the people of Israel" whose national existence is timeless and permanent (82)."

- Japhet, Sara. *The Ideology of the Book of Chronicles*

> According to the Chronicler, the history of the people begins with its creation, in other words: with Adam. From the instant they come into being, the people of Israel is YHWH's people. The bond between Israel and God is not created — it already exists. It exists *a priori*, by virtue of the people's existence; YHWH is, by definition, the God of Israel (92).

- The Chronicler emphasizes that Yahweh is the God of Israel and Israel is Yahweh's people—not because of anything the people have done or not done, but by their very existence (Japhet 97).
- **In times of crisis, why is it important to remember that God keeps his promises? And promises made yesterday, still apply today.**

Manasseh

The worst king?

- Manasseh was one of Judah's final kings before the Babylonian exile.
- His reign takes place before the religious reforms of Josiah (another Judahite king).
- Chronicles portrays Manasseh differently than Kings.
- Below is an outline of the story of Manasseh as told by Kings and Chronicles:

Manasseh according to 2 Kings:

- Manasseh rises to power and does what is evil in the sight of the Lord (Ch. 21:2)
    a. He rebuilt the high places, erected alters for Baal, and made a sacred pole (Ch. 21:3).
    b. He performed child sacrifice, soothsaying / augury, and dealt with mediums and wizards (Ch. 21:6).
    c. He also, "shed very much innocent blood" (Ch. 21:16).
- Because Manasseh committed these abominations (Ch. 21:11) the Lord, the God of Israel will "[bring] upon Jerusalem and Judah such evil that the ears of everyone who hears of it will tingle" (Ch. 21:12).
- Manasseh dies (Ch. 21:18).
- Later, even after Josiah's reform (Ch. 22 - 23), we learn that "Still the Lord did not turn from the fierceness of his great wrath, by which his anger was kindled against Judah, because of all the provocations with which Manasseh had provoked him" (Ch. 23:26).
- Eventually, the Lord sent the Chaldeans, Arameans, Moabites, and Ammonites to destroy Judah (Ch. 24:2).
- This came upon Judah "for the sins of Manasseh, for all that he had committed, and also for the innocent blood that he had shed" (Ch. 24:3-4).

- Doorly, William. *The Religion of Israel*

> For the DH historian, Manasseh was more valuable as a straw man. He is completely an example of an ungodly Judean leader with no redeeming features, a complete contrast to Hezekiah, his father, and Josiah, his grandson (144).

- **The blame for the exile is placed squarely on Manasseh's shoulders. His story is one of total rejection of God.**

Manasseh according to 2 Chronicles:

- Manasseh rises to power and does what is evil in the sight of the Lord (Ch. 33:2).
    a. He rebuilt the high places, erected alters for Baal, and made sacred poles (Ch. 33:3).
    b. He performed child sacrifice, soothsaying / augury, and dealt with mediums and wizards (Ch. 33:6).
    c. "Manasseh mislead Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, so that they did more evil than the nations whom the Lord had destroyed before the people of Israel" (Ch. 33:9).
- Manasseh is captured by the Assyrians and brought to Babylon (Ch. 33:11).
- While in distress, Manasseh "entreated the favor of the Lord his God and humbled himself greatly before the God of his ancestors" (Ch. 33:12).
- God hears his plea and restores Manasseh to his kingdom in Jerusalem. "Then Manasseh knew that the Lord indeed was God" (Ch. 33:13).
- Manasseh proceeds to institute religious reform:
    - He took away the foreign gods from the house of the Lord (Ch. 33:15).
    - He offered sacrifices to the Lord (Ch. 33:16)
- Despite commanding the people of Judah to serve the Lord (Ch. 33:16), "The people, however, still sacrificed at the high places, but only to the Lord their God" (Ch. 33:17).
- The Chronicler mentions that Manasseh's prayer to God is written down in the "records of the seers" (Ch. 33:19). This line inspired the apocryphal work *The Prayer of Manasseh.*

- Manasseh dies (Ch. 33:20).
- Later, even after Josiah's reform (Ch. 34 - 35), we learn that "the wrath of the Lord against his people became so great that there was no remedy" (Ch. 36:16). However, this wrath is *not* attributed to the sins of Manasseh, instead, the reason in Chronicles is that the *people* were unfaithful (Ch. 36:14) and mocked the messengers of God (Ch. 36:16).
- The blame for the exile in Chronicles is a result of the *people's* actions; Manasseh is a portrait of repentance. Even *Manasseh* can be saved.

- In Kings, Manasseh is blamed for the exile. He is an evil king with no redemption.
- In Chronicles, Manasseh is an evil king *at first.* But after realizing that "the Lord indeed was God" Manasseh is redeemed. He is saved. His exile is ended. All he needed to do was call out to the Lord and the Lord was there.

- **Why is it important to remember that even someone like Manasseh can be saved?**
- **Given everything outlined above, how does Chronicles' portrayal of God differ from that of Kings?**

Conclusion

- The Chronicler reinterprets previously written scripture to make theological statements.
- Enns, Peter. *The Evolution of Adam*

> Chronicles is not a "history" such as we might expect as modern readers. It is a "theological history" that can only be properly understood as a response to the exile (54).

- By retelling Israel's story, the Chronicler emphasizes God's *sovereignty and grace* for his audience.
- Where Samuel and Kings are focused on God's justice; how God was correct for allowing the exile, Chronicles is focused on demonstrating how God is faithful and is still present and active today.
- Smith, Mark S. *The Early History of God*

> Israel's position in a foreign land threatened the validity of its religious heritage and the centrality of Yahweh; the Exile changed the circumstances of national life and therefore altered the definition of Yahweh's centrality. The radical circumstances of the Exile issued in a radical redefinition of Yahweh (196).

- The reality of the exile compelled the Chronicler to consider God differently.
- Chronicles' presence in our Biblical canon affirms that it is acceptable (if not celebrated) to consider God differently. To wrestle with God.
- This is not the only place in our Bible where the Bible reinterprets *itself*:
  - The Gospel authors: Mark was the first Gospel to be written. Matthew and Luke used Mark to tell the same story in different ways (Ehrman, *Misquoting Jesus* 135).
  - Paul (Enns, TEOA Ch. 6)
- Ehrman, Bart. *Jesus Interrupted*

> Most people do not read the Bible this way. They assume that since all the books in the Bible are found between the same hard covers, every author is basically saying the same thing. They think that Matthew can be used to help understand John, John provides insights into Paul, Paul can help interpret the book of James, and so on. This harmonizing approach to the Bible, which is foundational to much devotional reading, has the advantage of helping readers see the unifying themes of the Bible, but it also has very serious drawbacks, often creating unity of thought and belief where originally there was none. The biblical authors did not agree on everything they discussed; sometimes they had deeply rooted and significant disagreements (62 - 63).

- If you are in crisis. If you have doubts. If your reality is inconsistent with what your Bible says about God. If you need to reinterpret your Bible, you are in good company.

Sources

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VI. Higashi, Aaron. *1 & 2 Samuel For Normal People.* The Bible for Normal People, 2024

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Additional References / Resources

I. The Bible for Normal People Podcast:

   I. Pete Ruins 1 Kings

   II. Pete Ruins 2 Kings

   III. Pete Ruins Chronicles

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